

## Not at all bo(a)ring!

**T**he *Truman Show* is truly a Peter Weir masterpiece. It has Jim Carrey as the subject of a never-ending movie on his life where cameras follow his every move, and all the people around him—his friends, his wife and the rest of the city—are nothing but actors. The movie was released in 1998, and almost earned Carrey an Oscar nomination.

We will never be able to tell you whether the nameless wild boar family on the Web site

[www.wildtiere-live.de](http://www.wildtiere-live.de) is ever nominated for any recognition, but if popularity is any indicator, then its 56 family members—six grown-ups and 50 offspring—are nothing short of superstars. Just two weeks after the German Hunting Protection League launched the Pig Brother Web site, the porcine family has attracted more than 1.5 million visitors, and over 400 guest book entries.

The site records each and



every moment of their lives using a web cam in an enclosure in their natural habitat of the Eifel Mountains in western Germany.

We're glad that the Internet cannot transmit smell as yet!

## ... And hardware falls down!

**W**as it just another speech, or did Bill Gates really mean it? It so happened that at the recent Gartner Symposium Itpo in San Diego, the high priest of the IT world, Bill Gates III predicted that in the next 10 years or so, hardware prices will fall to the point where widespread computing with speech and handwriting won't be limited by expensive technology.

If indeed this turns out to be true, it would have far-reaching implications on the hardware industry. Microsoft, already the world's largest software maker, is now also a big hardware manufacturer, leading the way in tablet PCs and SPOT watches. Gates is betting on the premise that all devices in the future will be tablet-size. Advances in programming will allow software developers to create applications in less time, using visual representations of the inner workings of software, rather than writing lines of programming code.

We think he should have a fair idea about what he is talking, specially since his company spends \$6.8 billion (approx Rs 3,000 crore) a year on research.

We have an issue with his statement, though. Leading lights have always promised fall in prices, and that has actually happened, but the digital divide is growing wider than ever before.

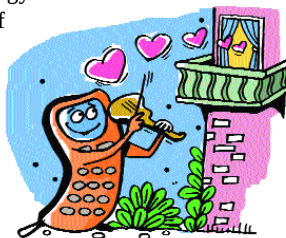
We see only one reason for this: when prices fall for on product, it so happens that the rest of the world moves to a new standard, and the cheap product becomes obsolete. Take the VCR, for instance. By the time it was affordable to the masses, we had moved to VCDs, and by the time VCD players were with in budget, in came the DVD, and so on.

What are your views? Will the digital divide ever be bridged, especially with hardware? Let us know your opinion at [billgates@thinkdigit.com](mailto:billgates@thinkdigit.com).

## Stupid Cupid just went mobile

**A**nd you thought the geeks at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology had no heart! A team of young, imaginative scientists have developed a service that would help you find your ideal partner if he or she is somewhere in your vicinity.

All you have to do is subscribe to a service called Serendipity, which then puts you in the database for mobile phone dating. The service stores in their phones, a personal profile and information on what they



want from a partner.

If the people whose profiles match are in the vicinity of each other, the service prompts their phones to communicate with the other.

One problem: what happens if there are multiple matches? Now that would be some position to be in! If you believe mobile dating actually works, write in to us at [mobile-cupid@thinkdigit.com](mailto:mobile-cupid@thinkdigit.com).

## heroes

### Linux

Steven Spielberg's DreamWorks Animation will be using Linux for its upcoming films—*Shrek*, *Shark Tale* and *Madagascar*. A thousand computers will comprise the HP Utility Rendering Service (URS), which will be used for on-site animation rendering and remote collaboration. The URS is based on HP servers running Linux.

### Broadband

One-third of all adult Americans now have access to high-speed Internet connections. A UK ISP has begun a new entry-level ADSL service that costs the same as many dial-up services.

British Telecom is stretching the reach of its current service, and will start a 2 MB service later this year.

## zeroes

### Spam fighting

Spam received by businesses has doubled over the last two years. Analysts say 32 per cent of all e-mail sent per day in North America in 2003 was spam. The effect of spam, measured in lost worker productivity and wasted resources, and comes to millions of dollars annually for larger organisations.

### Sun Microsystems

Sun Microsystems' woes are compounding: a third quarter net loss of \$760 million, and the laying off of 9 per cent of its workforce. There's also tough competition from Dell and HP to reckon with.